



# Christopher Walken

Esteemed and loved actor. You might have seen him in:

- The Deer Hunter (1978, Oscar for Best Supporting Actor)
- King of New York (1990)
- Pulp Fiction (1994)
- True Romance (1993)
- SNL (e.g., More Cowbell, 2000)
- Weapon of Choice (Fatboy Slim/Spike Jonze music video, 2001)
- Catch Me If You Can (2002)
- Dune: Part 2 (2024)
- Severance (2025)

...and numerous other films, TV shows, stage plays, ads, music videos and video games.



What's the story here?

# Storytelling and Narratives in Business (BUSN 42124)

Prof. Guy Rolnik

# Session 2: All Audiences Are Not Created Equal

# Our definition of “Story”

A **sequence of events** in a **protagonist's** life that, through the **resolution** of a specific **conflict**, conveys an intended **idea** to a chosen **audience**

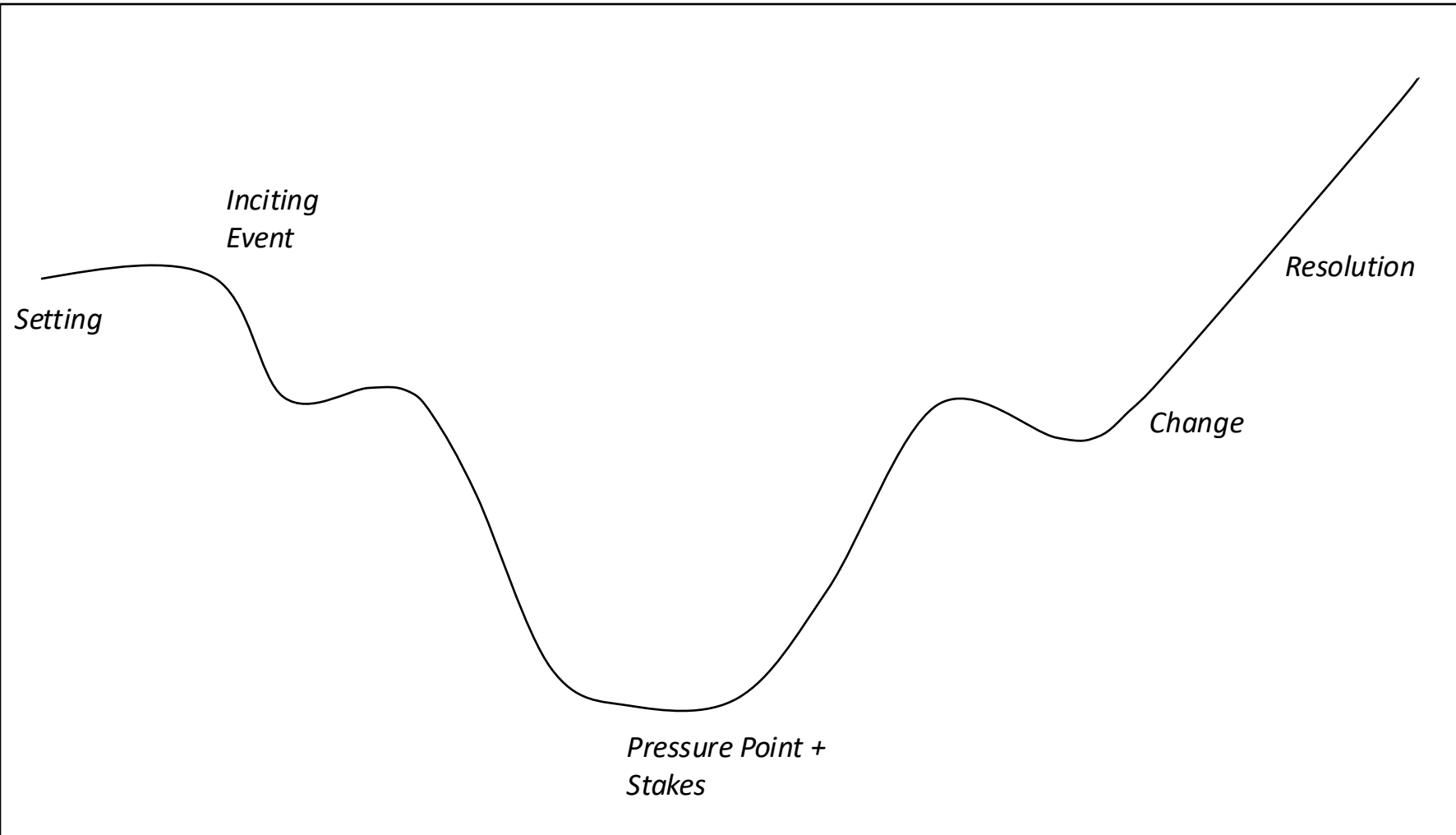
# Story Headline

Purpose: WIIFM?

**The Audience**  
Who are they?  
WIIFT?  
Beliefs

**Controlling Idea**

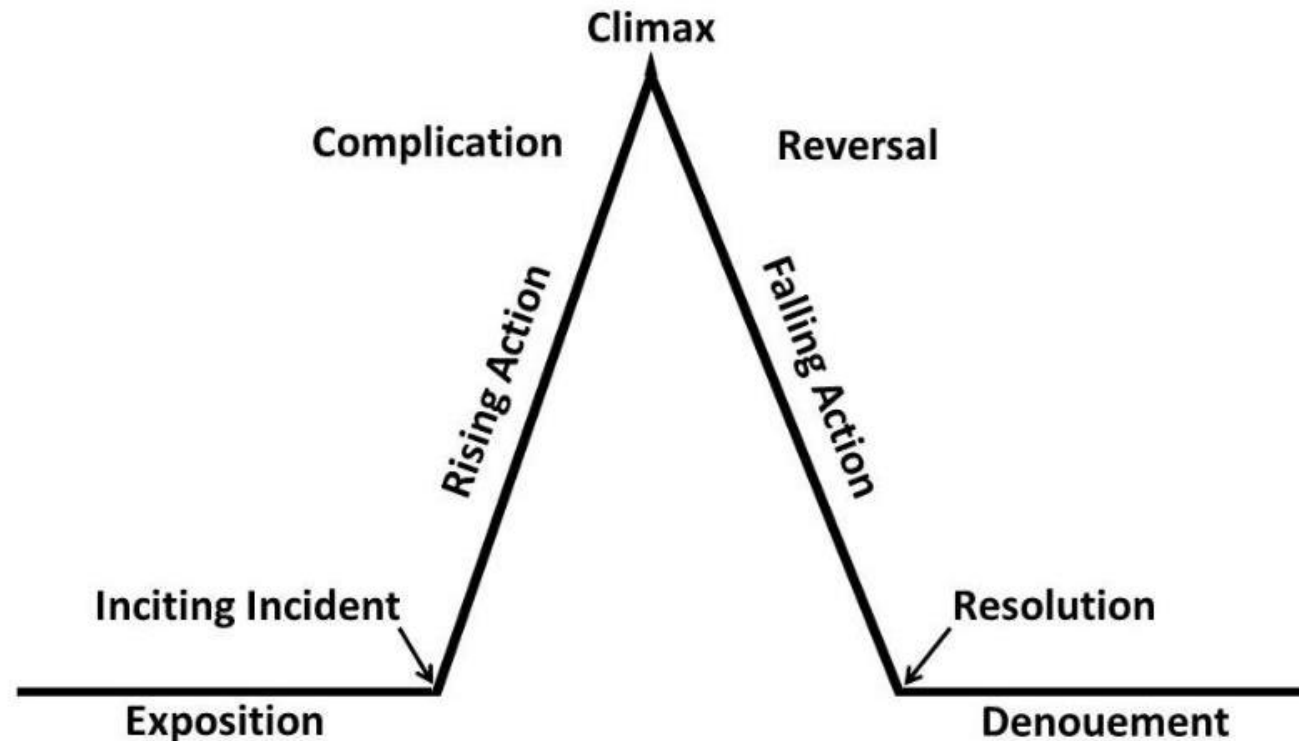
Protagonist  
Antagonist  
Conflict



## Creative techniques

- ☐ Limitations
- ☐ Details, facts, anecdotes
- ☐ Mystery Box
- ☐ Metaphors
- ☐ Cultural references
- ☐ Simplicity
- ☐ Show, don't tell
- ☐ Interact

# Freytag's Pyramid

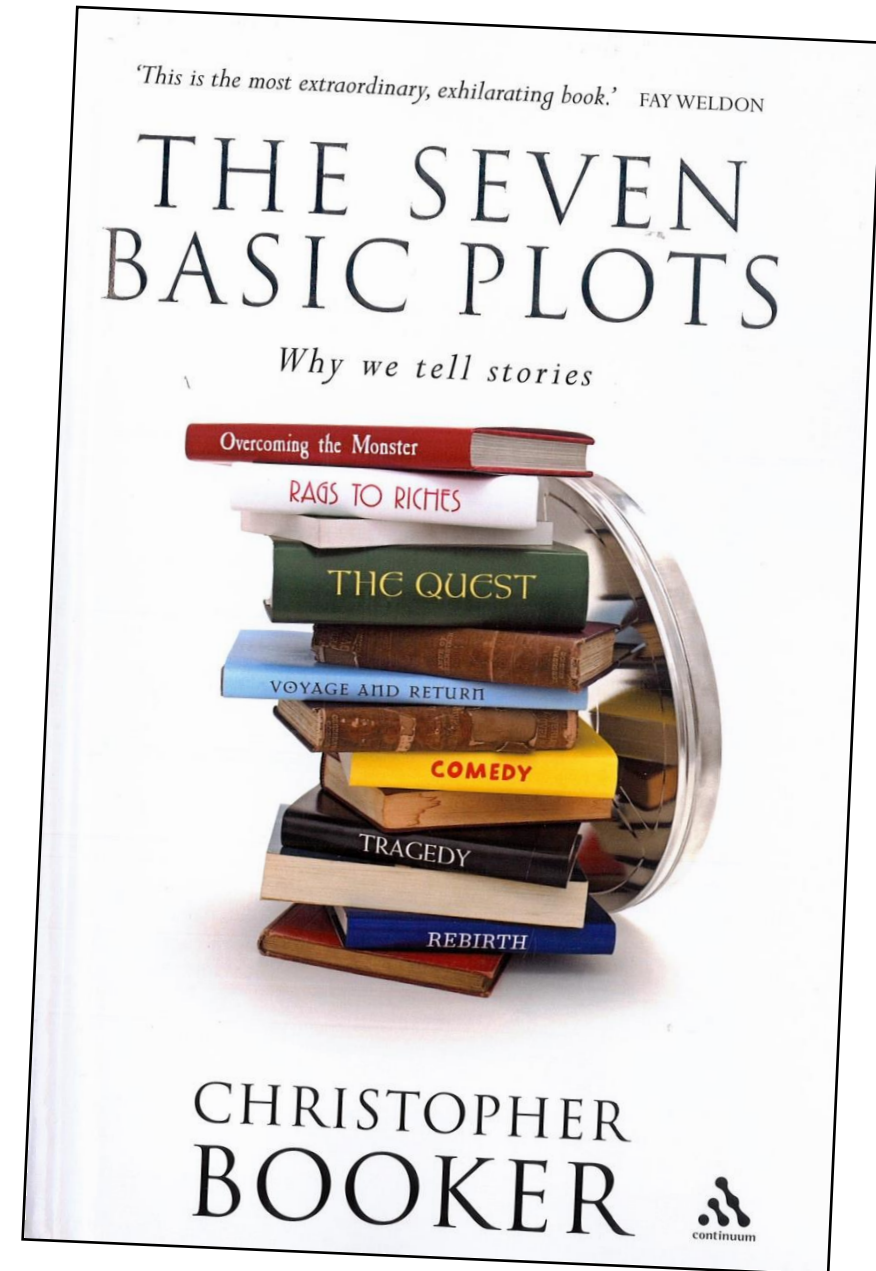


Gustav Freytag, 19<sup>th</sup> century German novelist and playwright, based his theory of dramatic structure on Aristotle's thinking. He drew this in 1863.



# The 7 basic plots

- The Quest
- Overcoming The Monster
- Voyage and Return
- Rags to Riches
- Rebirth
- Comedy
- Tragedy



# The meta-plot

In essence, we have told one another the same tale, one way or another, since the dawn of humanity:

For better or worse, an event throws a character's life out of balance, arousing in him the conscious and/or unconscious desire for that which he feels will restore balance, launching him on a quest for his object of desire against forces of antagonism (inner, personal, extra-personal).

This is story in a nutshell.

# Session 2 plot

- Our brains are wired for stories
- Defining a story's Purpose
- Knowing your Audience
- Establishing a story's Controlling idea

Let's conduct a little  
experiment



What did you see?

# Our brains are wired for story

# Mirror neurons

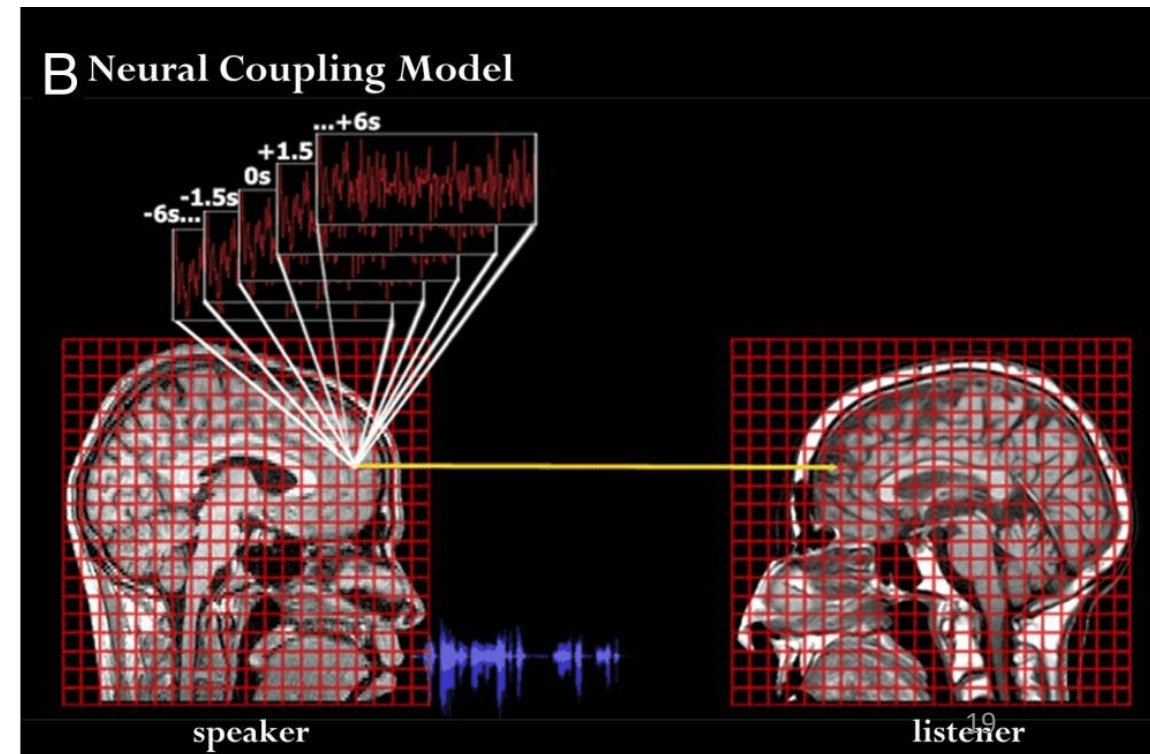
In the 1990s, Italian neuroscientists implanted electrodes into a monkey's brain to discover which neural regions were responsible for commanding certain actions.

The scientists discovered that specific areas of a monkey's brain light up not only when they get a nut, but also **when they see another monkey or person get a nut.**



# Neural Coupling

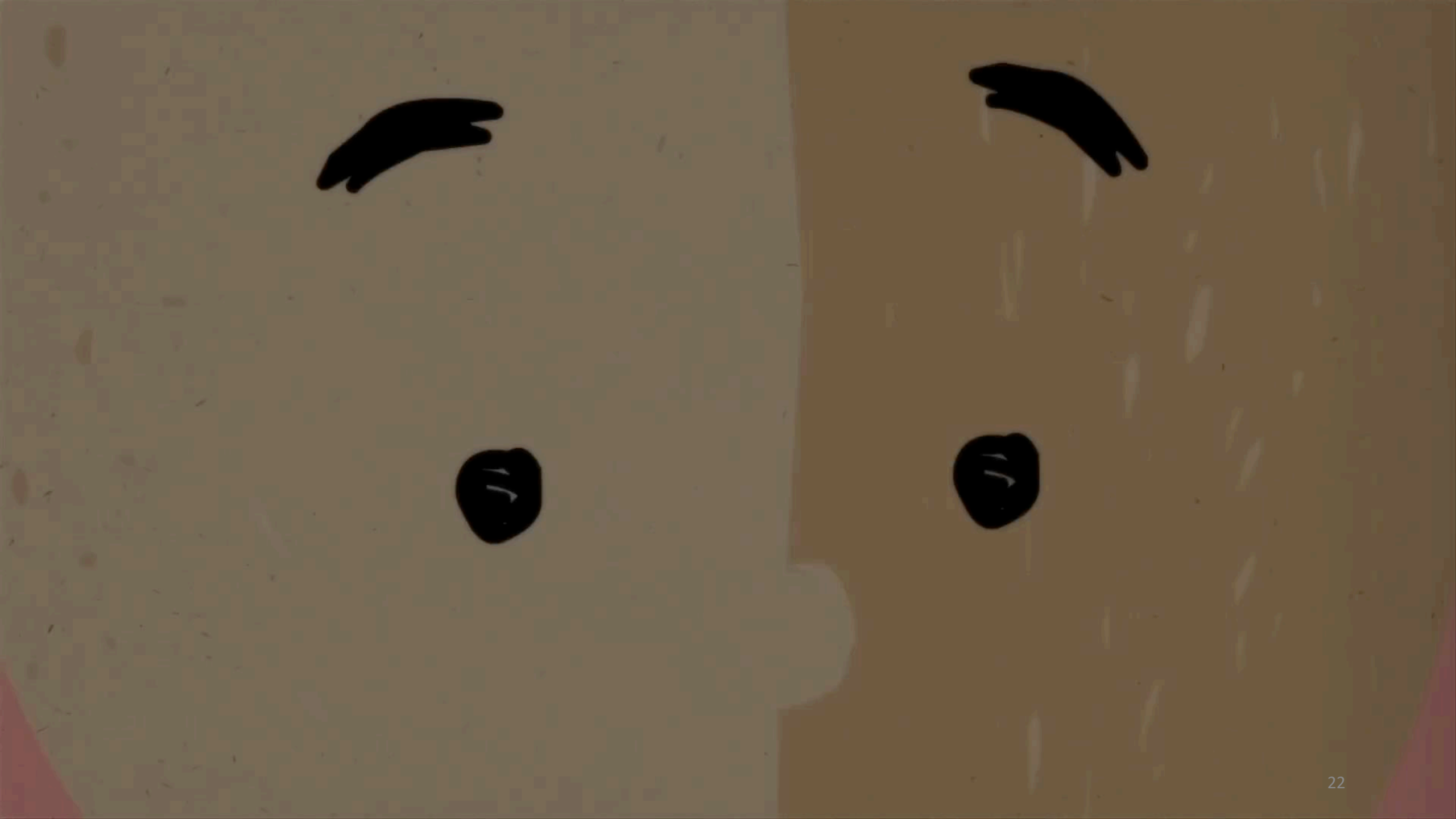
- Using fMRI brain scans, Uri Hasson recorded the brain activity of a person telling a real-life story (an experience she had at her high-school prom)
- Hasson measured the brain activity of people listening to the story as well as the brain activity of people resting (without hearing the story)
- He discovered the **brains of both teller and listener show patterns of activity in exactly the same areas**



Knowing that fiction is fiction  
doesn't stop the emotional brain  
from processing it as real

# Transportation Theory

- When people hear a story they get “**transported**” – absorbed in it
- They become **emotionally involved with the characters**, which might lead to a change in beliefs
- Two conditions raise the chances of “transportation”:
  - You have to empathize with one or more of the characters
  - Those character/s have to endure struggle



Show of hands:  
How many of you got emotional  
watching this clip?

How many were overwhelmed  
with emotion?

# What's happening here?

# Brain hack



# Why did this happen?



# The power of Oxytocin

- Paul Zak discovered that storytelling can be used to “hack” oxytocin\* levels in a person’s brain
- In research, **stories** captured on video **raised the oxytocin levels** in the brains of subjects who watched the videos
- Zak discovered that to ignite a desire to help others, a story must first sustain attention by developing **narrative tension**
- Viewers are likely to **share characters’ emotions** – and will even continue mimicking the feelings and behaviors of the characters **after** the story ends

Can you get the same, strong  
reaction – to a **happy** story?

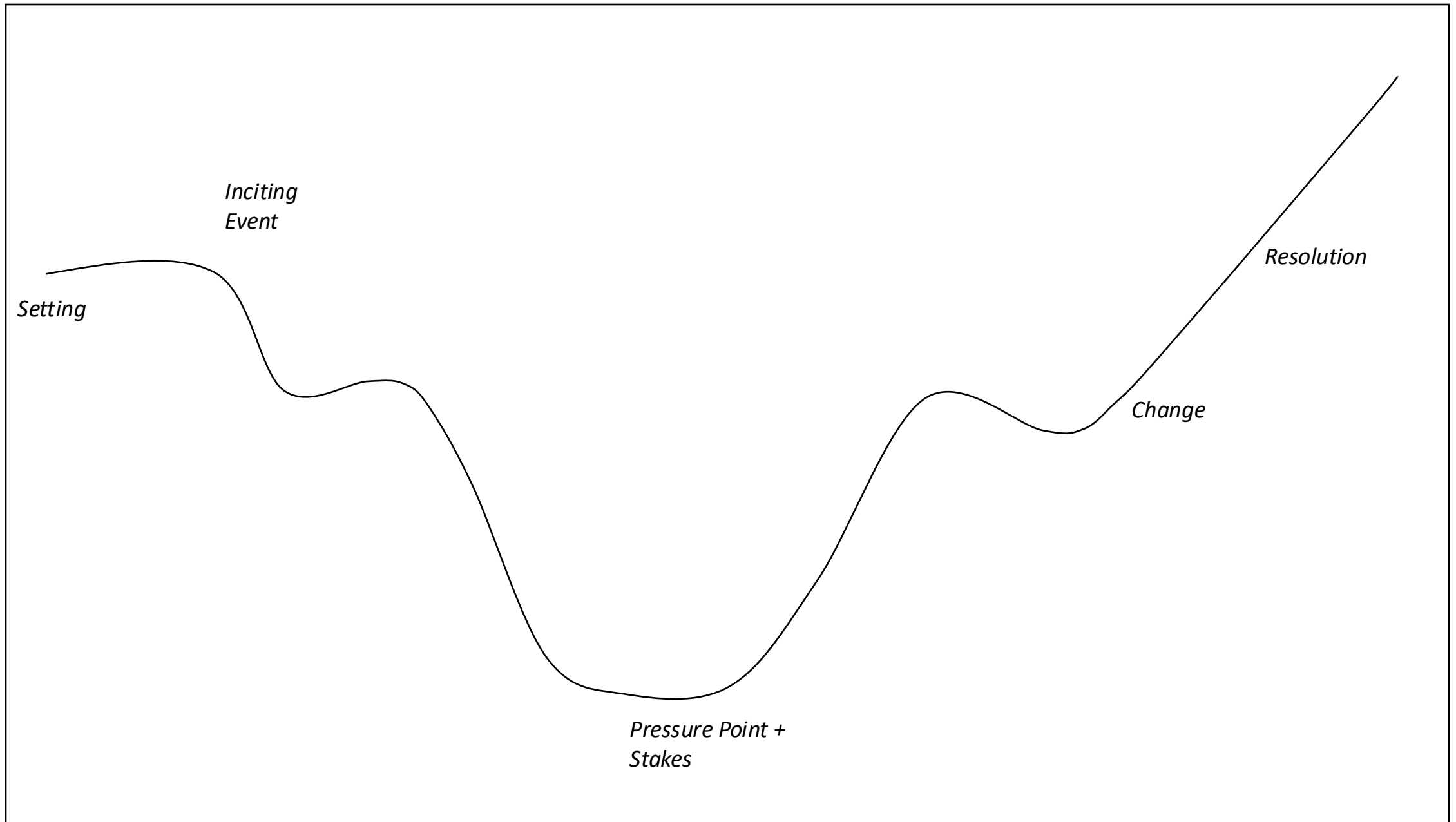
WARM SPRINGS

Puppy  
Adoption



# Questions...

- What is the story here?
- Was this story effective?
- If so, why was it effective?



# Story is the language of experience

## Reading Stories Activates Neural Representations of Visual and Motor Experiences

**Nicole K. Speer, Jeremy R. Reynolds, Khena M. Swallow, and Jeffrey M. Zacks**

*Washington University in St. Louis*



# Stories as simulators

- Stories allow us to **simulate intense experiences** without actually having to live through them
- This was a matter of life and death in prehistoric times
  - If you waited for experience to teach you that the rustling in the bushes was actually a lion, you'd probably end up as prey
- In modern times, stories enable us to tackle the no-less-trickier social realm
- Research concludes there is **substantial overlap between the brain networks used to understand stories, and the networks used to navigate interactions with other individuals**

# A story is a simulator for life

An evolutionary “VR” technology that allows our brains to **practice reacting to the kinds of challenges** that are most **crucial to our success** in any context

# Stories hone our real-life skills

- Several studies showed that **individuals who frequently read fiction seem to be better able to understand other people**, empathize with them and see the world from their perspective
- This relationship persisted even after researchers accounted for the possibility that more empathetic individuals might prefer reading novels

Djikic, K. Oatley, Zoeterman and Peterson, On being moved by art: how reading fiction transforms the self, Creativity Research Journal 21, no. 1 (2009): 24-29

PhysOrg.com, Readers build vivid mental simulations of narrative situations, brain scans suggest, January 6 2009

Your brain on fiction, NY Times, March 17 2012

Novels with strong character development can help you think more creatively about handling interpersonal issues. Chances are, most of your office frustrations have to do with people – lazy colleagues, unresponsive clients, deadlocked negotiations.

Reading a novel... lets you gain insights into the ways people think

From this point on,  
think of stories as a...





# Trojan Horse

When we hear stories,  
and are moved emotionally,  
we drop our intellectual shields.

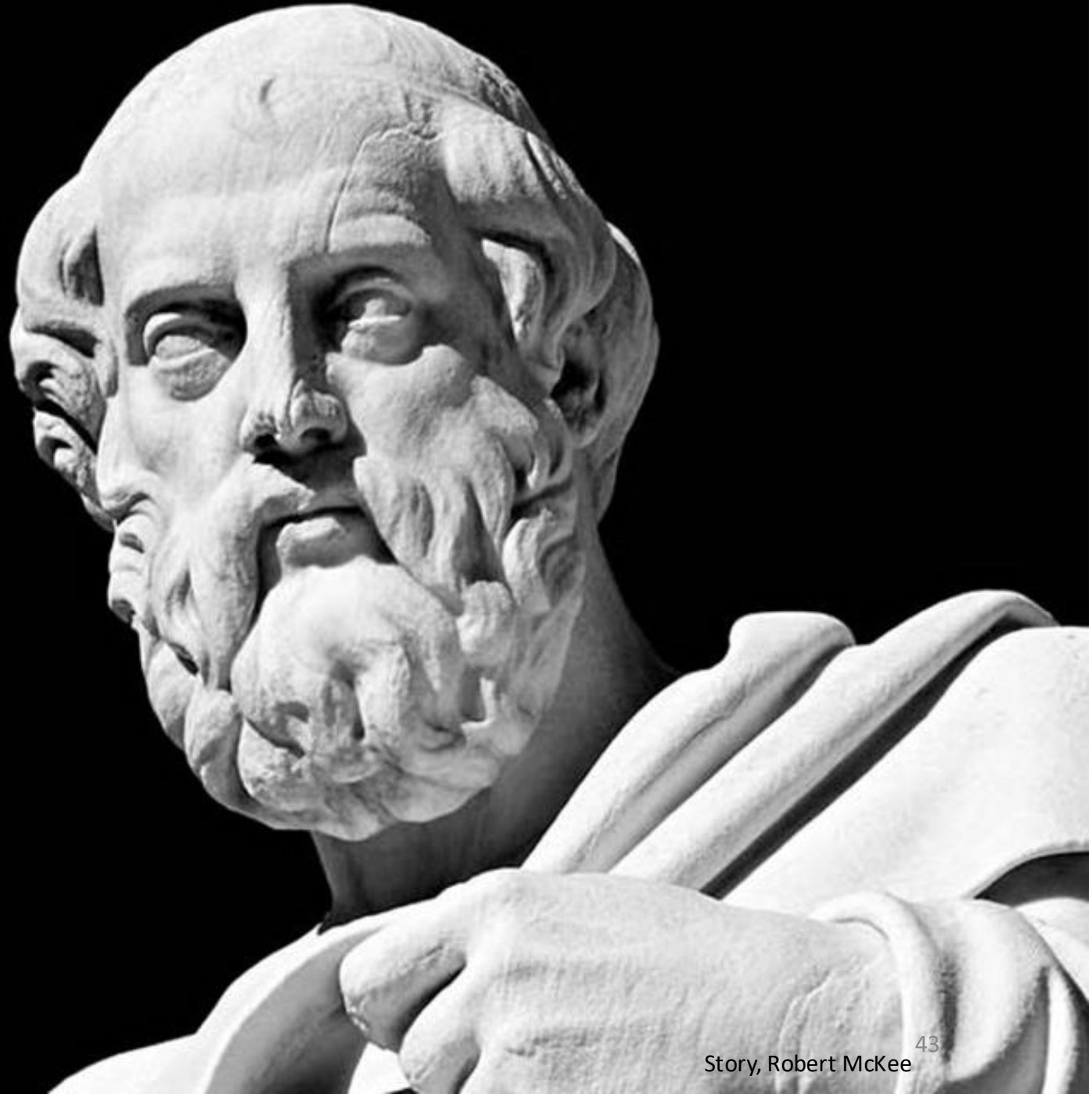
We are then less likely to critically evaluate facts –  
and are more open to changing our minds

In that sense,  
we become defenseless



In 388 B.C. Plato urged the city fathers of Athens to exile all poets and storytellers. They are a threat to society, he argued.

His logic was that writers deal with ideas – but not in the open, rational manner of philosophers. They conceal their ideas inside the seductive emotions of art.



# In short, our brains are wired for story

- Brain activity of listeners to stories mirrors those of story tellers
- Storytelling can be used to “hack” oxytocin and cortisol levels in a person’s brain
- Stories as simulators for life: Individuals who frequently read fiction are better able to understand other people and empathize with them
- Stories as Trojan horses: When hearing stories, we drop our intellectual shields, and are open to changing our mind

# On to the Story Arc Canvas!



Let's hit the road...





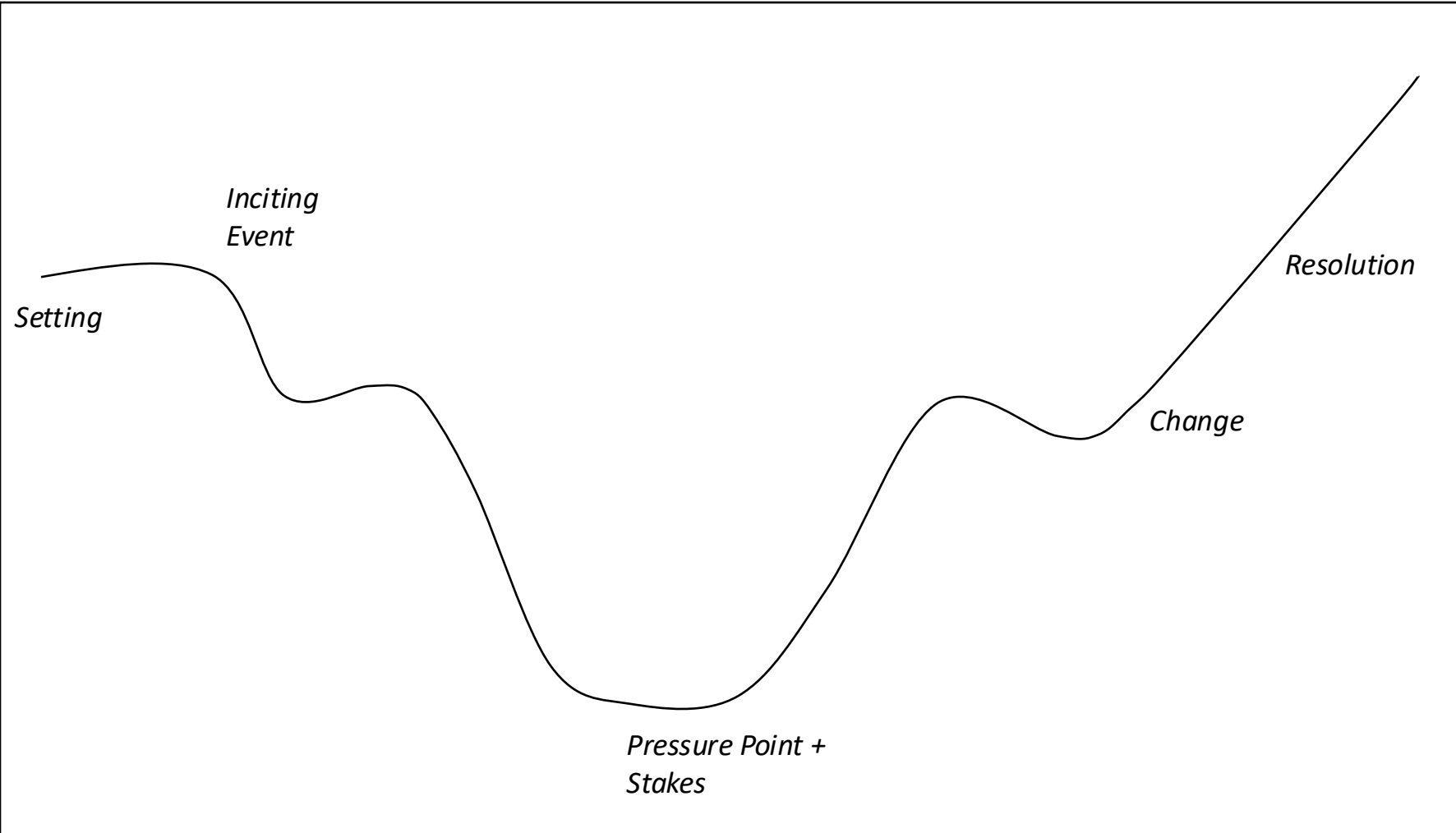
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Antagonist  
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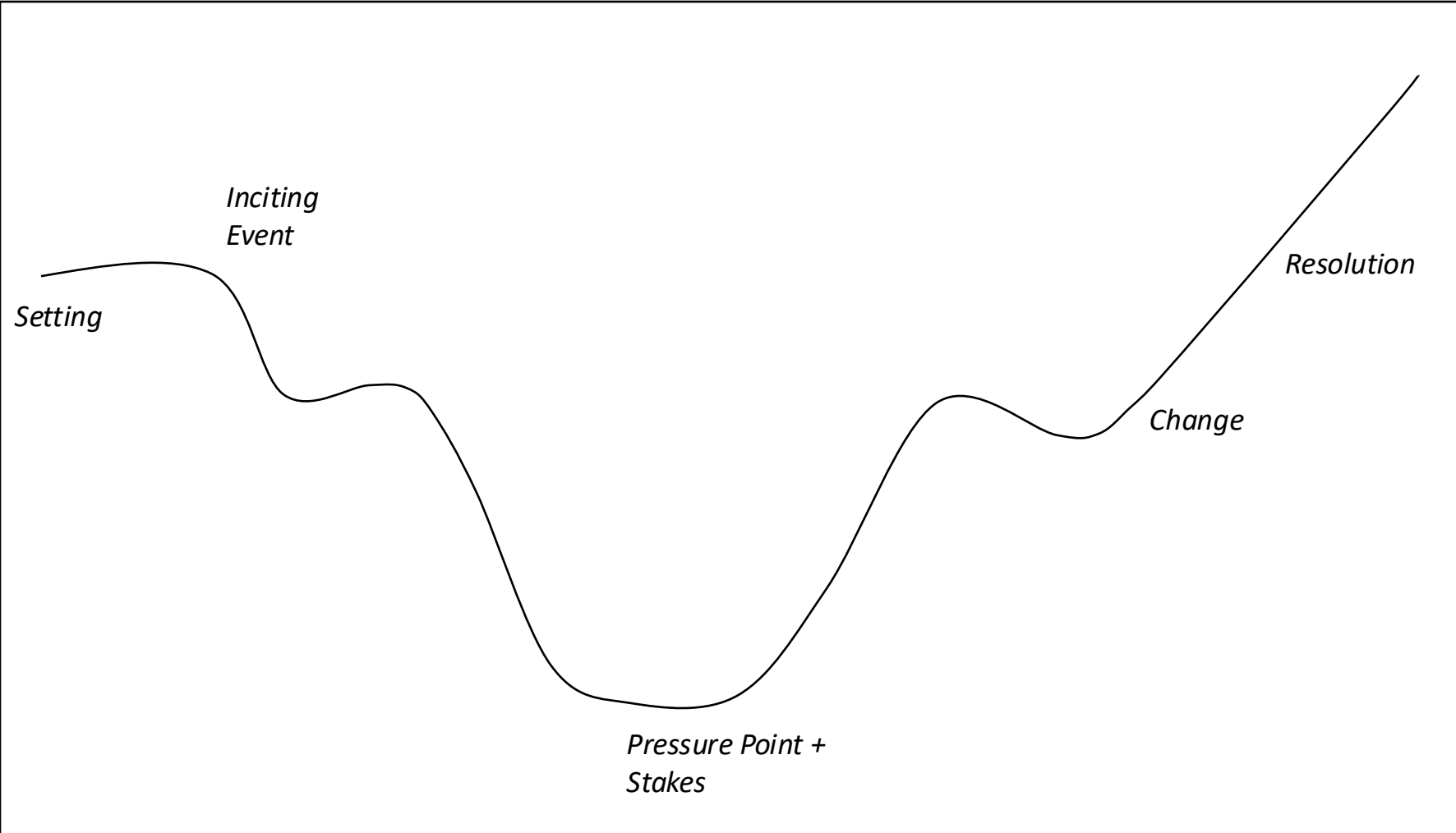
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Purpose:

What is it I want to **achieve**  
by telling this story?

# Common types of Purpose

- Communicating or selling **an idea, values or vision**
  - Leading company transformation
  - Lobbying a politician
- Communicating about or selling **a company, product or service**
  - Selling a product or a service
  - Influencing the media
  - Raising funds for a start-up
  - Recruiting employees
- Communicating about or “selling” **yourself**
  - Interviewing for a job
  - Undergoing a performance review



# Think-Feel-Do

Think in advance:

What would you like the audience to **think**?

What would you like them to **feel**?

What would you like them to **do**?

# Examples

- Who I Am
  - You want the audience to **feel/think** you possess certain qualities
- Why I Am Here
  - You want the audience to **understand** your objectives
- Teaching
  - You want the audience to **feel** a shared experience, and to act accordingly
- Vision
  - You want the audience to **think** of an exciting future, and to **move to action**
- Value in Action
  - You want the audience to **understand** your values, and to **behave** accordingly
- I Know What You Are Thinking
  - You want to **validate – or upend** – the audience's perceptions

After a 10-minute break, we'll  
return to the Story Arc Canvas –  
and to the audience

# BREAK

Knowing what what's in it for  
YOU is of course not enough

You have to think  
of **the audience**

# Story Headline

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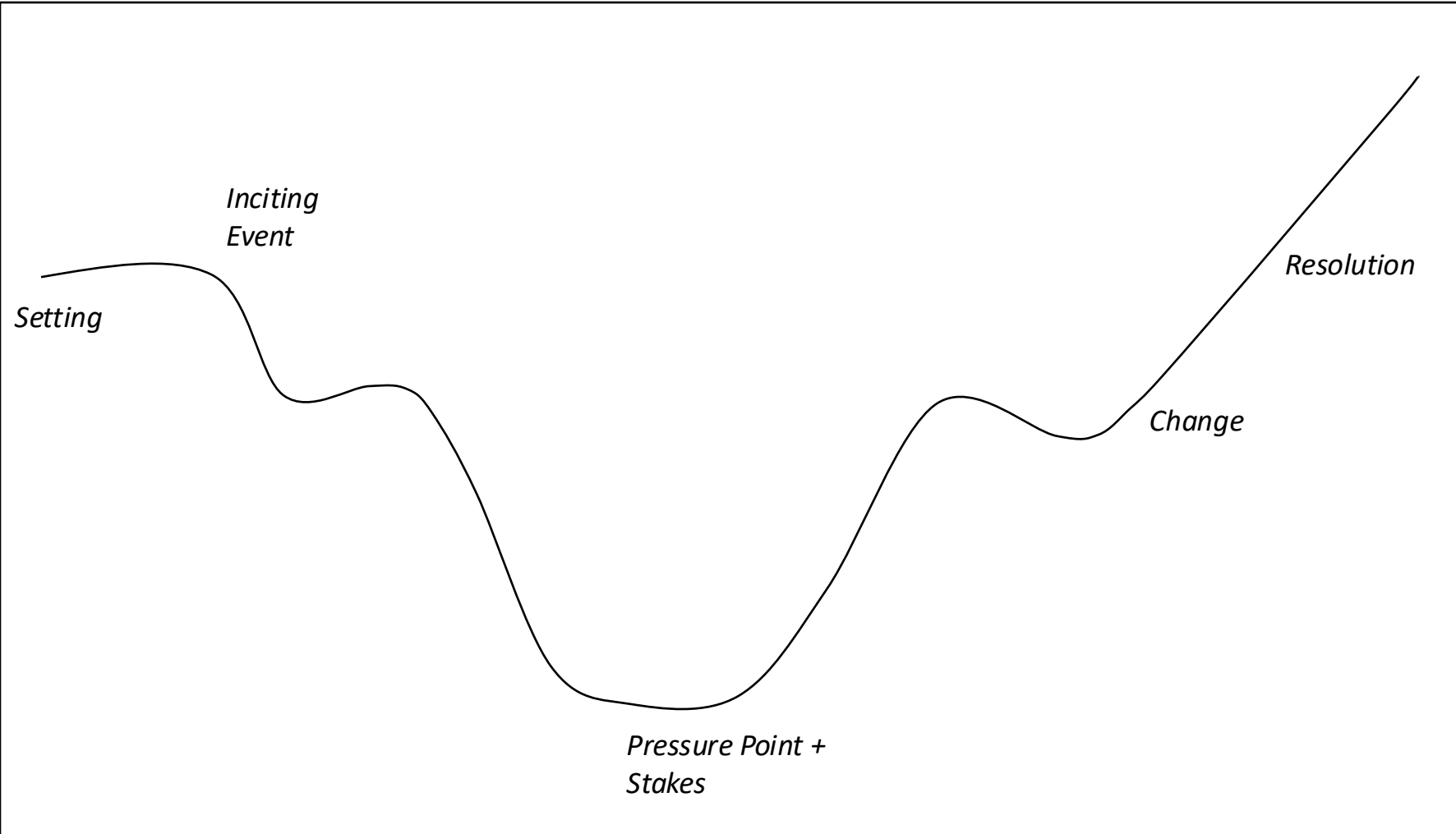
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The great storyteller takes time to understand  
**what his listeners know, care about,  
and want to hear.**

Then he crafts the essential elements of the story  
so that they resonate with those needs...  
bringing them along on an emotional journey.

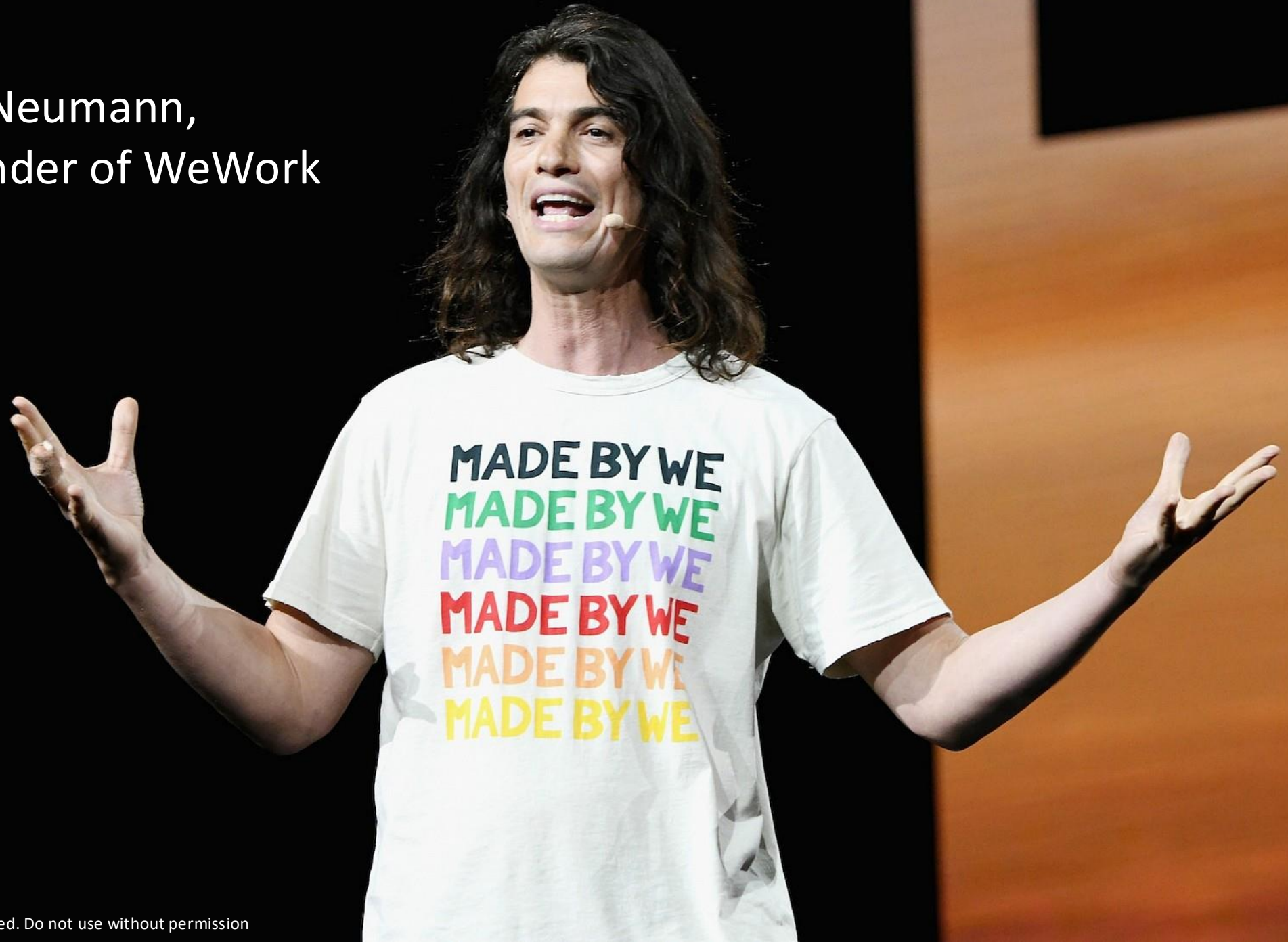


Remember:  
it's not about you –  
it's about them

# WIIFT

What's in it for **THEM** – the audience

Adam Neumann,  
co-founder of WeWork



academy award\* winner  
jared leto

academy award\* winner  
anne hathaway

A LOVE STORY  
WORTH \$47 BILLION

wecrashed



Setting the stage...

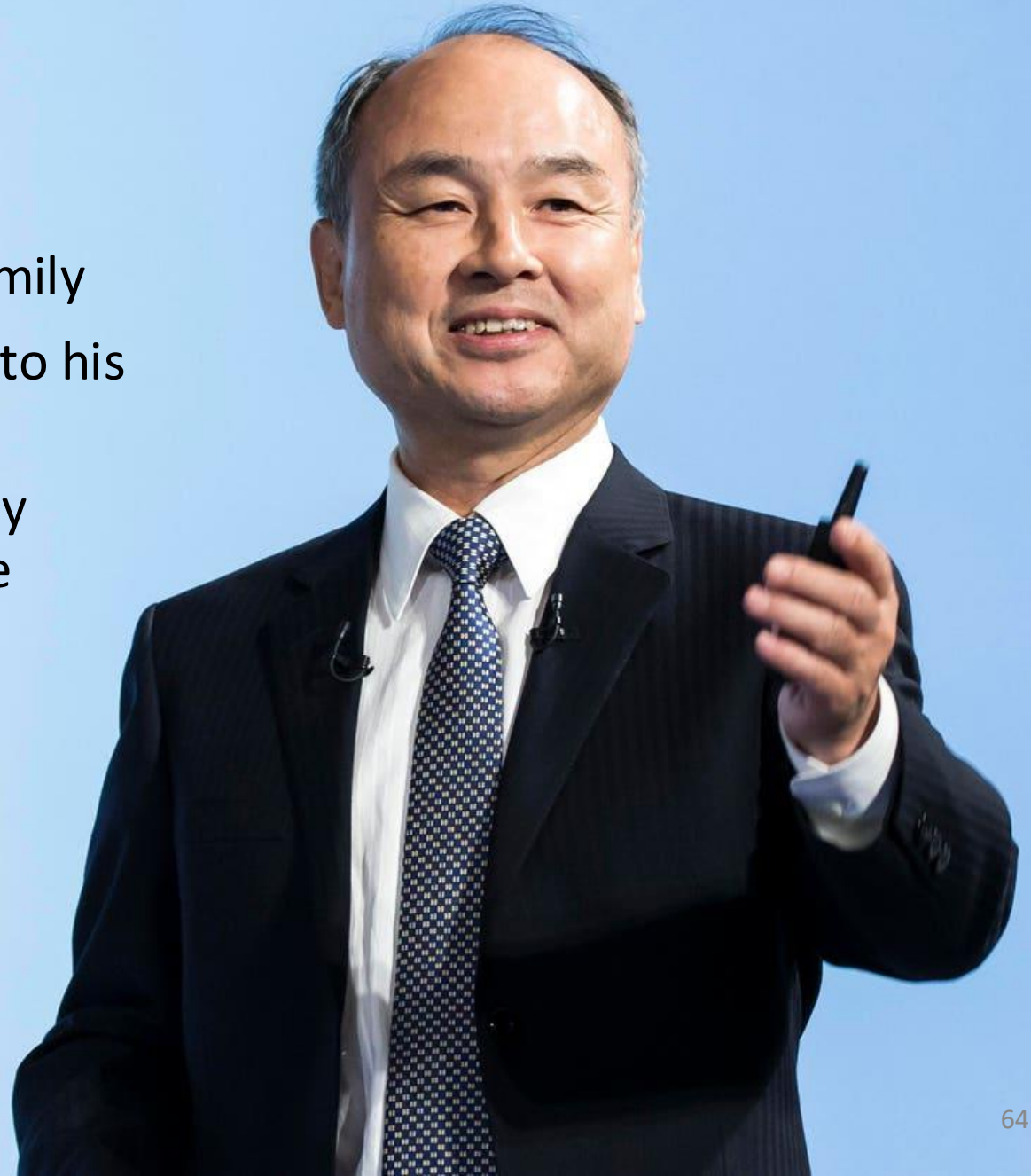
WeWork is about to run out of money,  
and Adam is looking for funding.

His target: Masayoshi Son, founder of  
Softbank and its \$100Bn Vision fund.



# Meet Masayoshi Son

- Born in Japan in 1957, to a Korean family
- Was frequently bullied at school due to his heritage
- Only when he came to the US to study did he start using his Korean surname (instead of Yasumoto)





# Discussion



In the next example –  
to whom is the storyteller  
telling his story?

# Setting the stage



- September 1985: Steve Jobs is ousted from the company he co-founded
- December 1996: Apple purchases NeXT, Jobs brought back on as advisor
- September 1997: Jobs is named iCEO
- At the time, 90 days of cash left
- Apple market cap at the end of 1997: ~2Bn

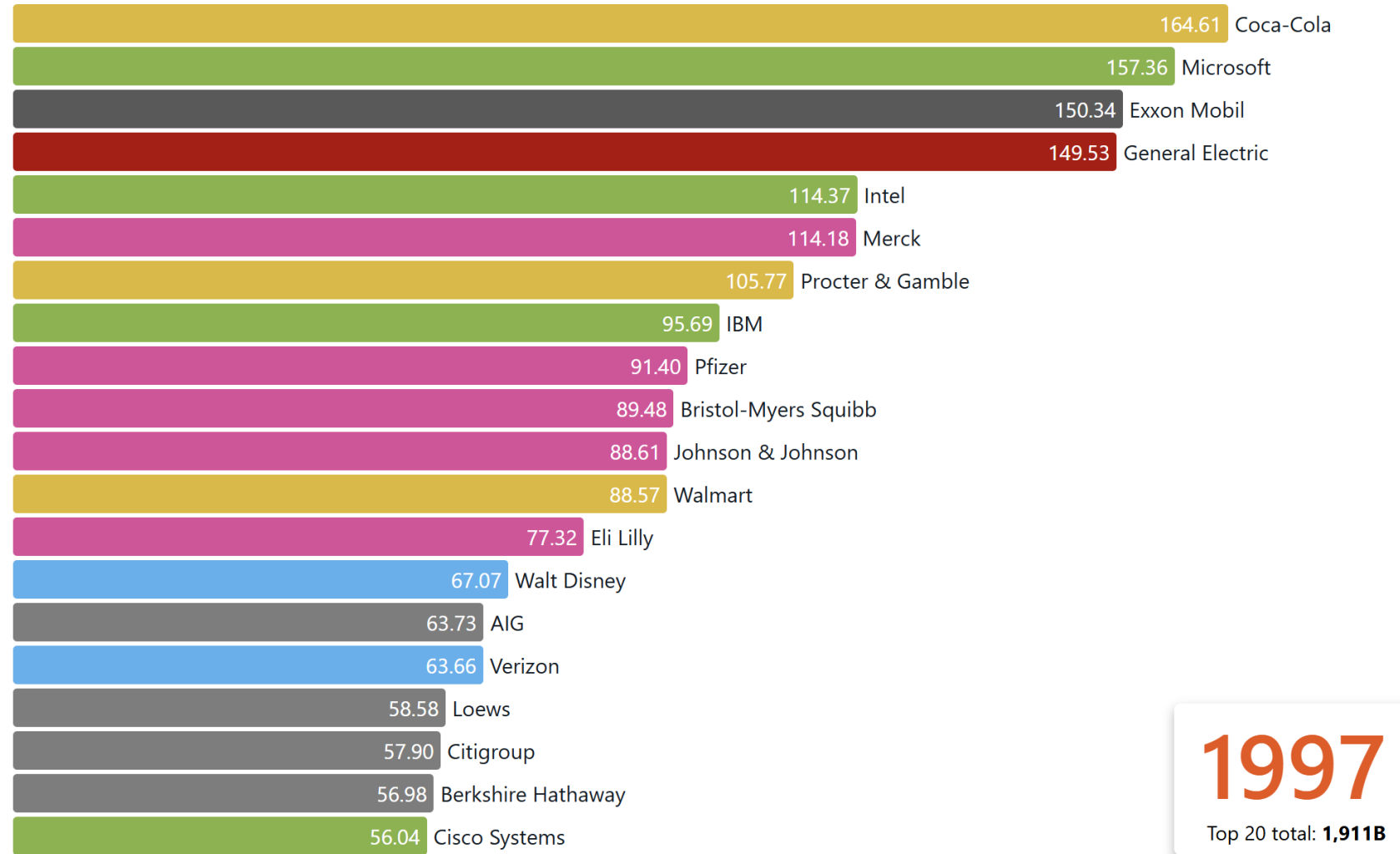
Apple product lineup, 1997





## Largest 20 S&P 500 Companies by Market Cap in 1997

(as of 12/31/1997, in billions USD)



Basic Materials Communication Services Consumer Cyclical Consumer Defensive Energy Financial Services Healthcare  
Industrials Technology Utilities

Source: compilation of data from Ycharts, Bloomberg.com, Fortune.com and Yahoo Finance.

When you watch this clip,  
focus on one question:  
**Who is the audience** for this ad?



# Featured in the ad:

|                                          |                                                                                                                                                          |
|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Albert Einstein</b>                   | German-born theoretical physicist.                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Bob Dylan</b>                         | American singer-songwriter.                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Martin Luther King Jr.</b>            | American Baptist minister and activist who was one of the most prominent leaders in the civil rights movement from 1955 until his assassination in 1968. |
| <b>Richard Branson</b>                   | British entrepreneur and business magnate.                                                                                                               |
| <b>John Lennon &amp; Yoko Ono</b>        | English singer, songwriter, musician and peace activist & Japanese multimedia artist, singer, songwriter, and peace activist.                            |
| <b>Buckminster Fuller</b>                | American architect, systems theorist, writer, designer, inventor, philosopher, and futurist.                                                             |
| <b>Thomas Edison</b>                     | American inventor and businessman.                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Muhammad Ali</b>                      | American professional boxer and activist.                                                                                                                |
| <b>Ted Turner</b>                        | American entrepreneur, television producer, media proprietor, and philanthropist.                                                                        |
| <b>Maria Callas</b>                      | American-born Greek soprano[2] who was one of the most renowned and influential opera singers of the 20th century.                                       |
| <b>Mahatma Gandhi</b>                    | Indian lawyer, anti-colonial nationalist and political ethicist.                                                                                         |
| <b>Amelia Earhart</b>                    | American aviation pioneer and writer.                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Alfred Hitchcock</b>                  | English filmmaker. He is widely regarded as one of the most influential figures in the history of cinema.                                                |
| <b>Martha Graham</b>                     | American modern dancer and choreographer.                                                                                                                |
| <b>Jim Henson (with Kermit the Frog)</b> | American puppeteer, animator, cartoonist, actor, inventor, and filmmaker who achieved worldwide notice as the creator of The Muppets and Fraggle Rock.   |
| <b>Frank Lloyd Wright</b>                | American architect, designer, writer, and educator.                                                                                                      |
| <b>Pablo Picasso</b>                     | Spanish painter, sculptor, printmaker, ceramicist and theatre designer who spent most of his adult life in France.                                       |



What's the story here,  
and to what audience?

“When I got back here,  
Apple had forgotten who we were.  
Remember that “Think Different”  
ad campaign we ran?  
It was... for customers to some degree,  
**but it was even more for Apple itself”**

Apple employees needed to  
believe in the company again.

What **audience beliefs**  
do you need to connect with –  
and/or change?

Once you know the audience and understand their beliefs, think of the **controlling idea** of your story

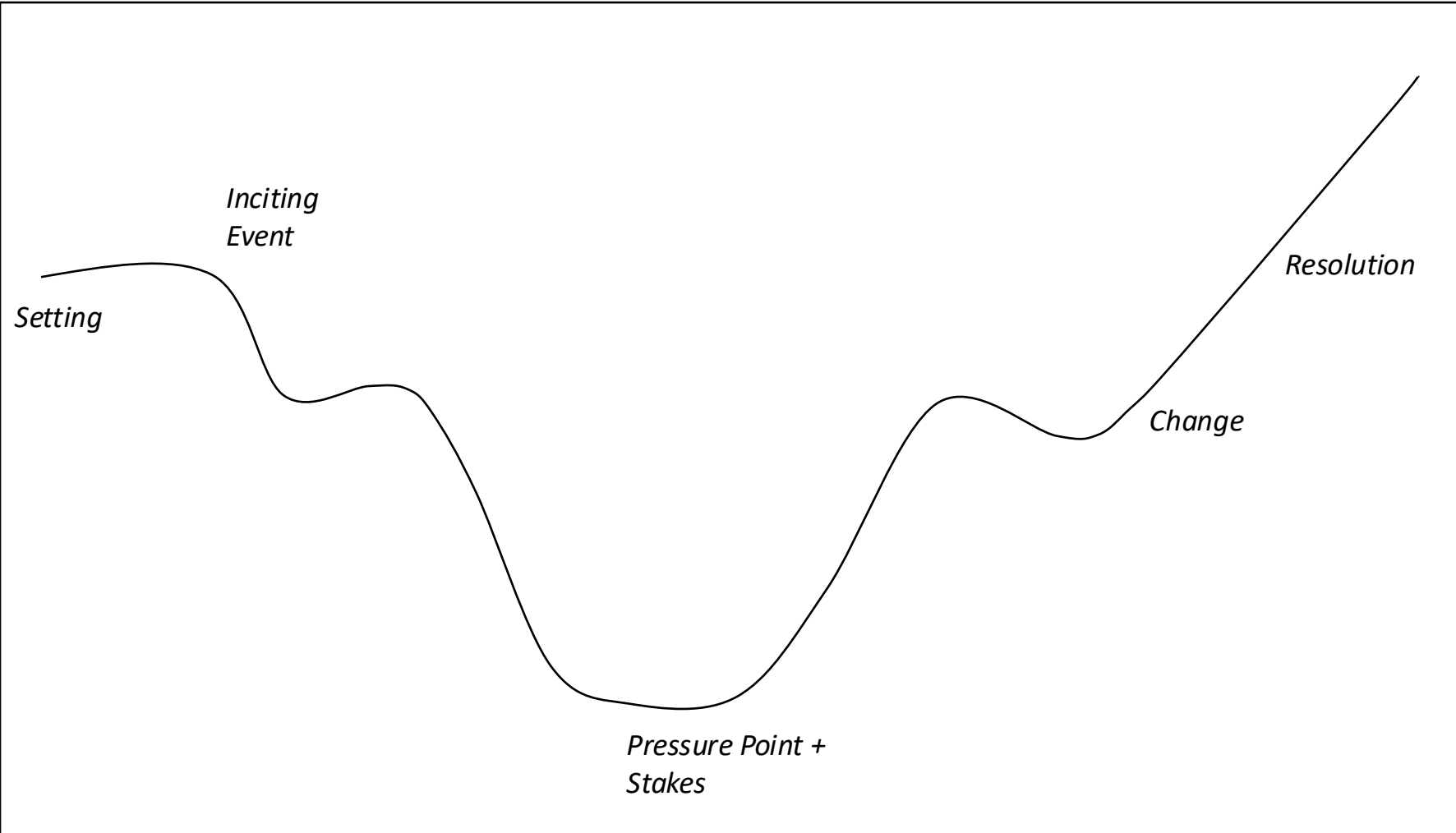
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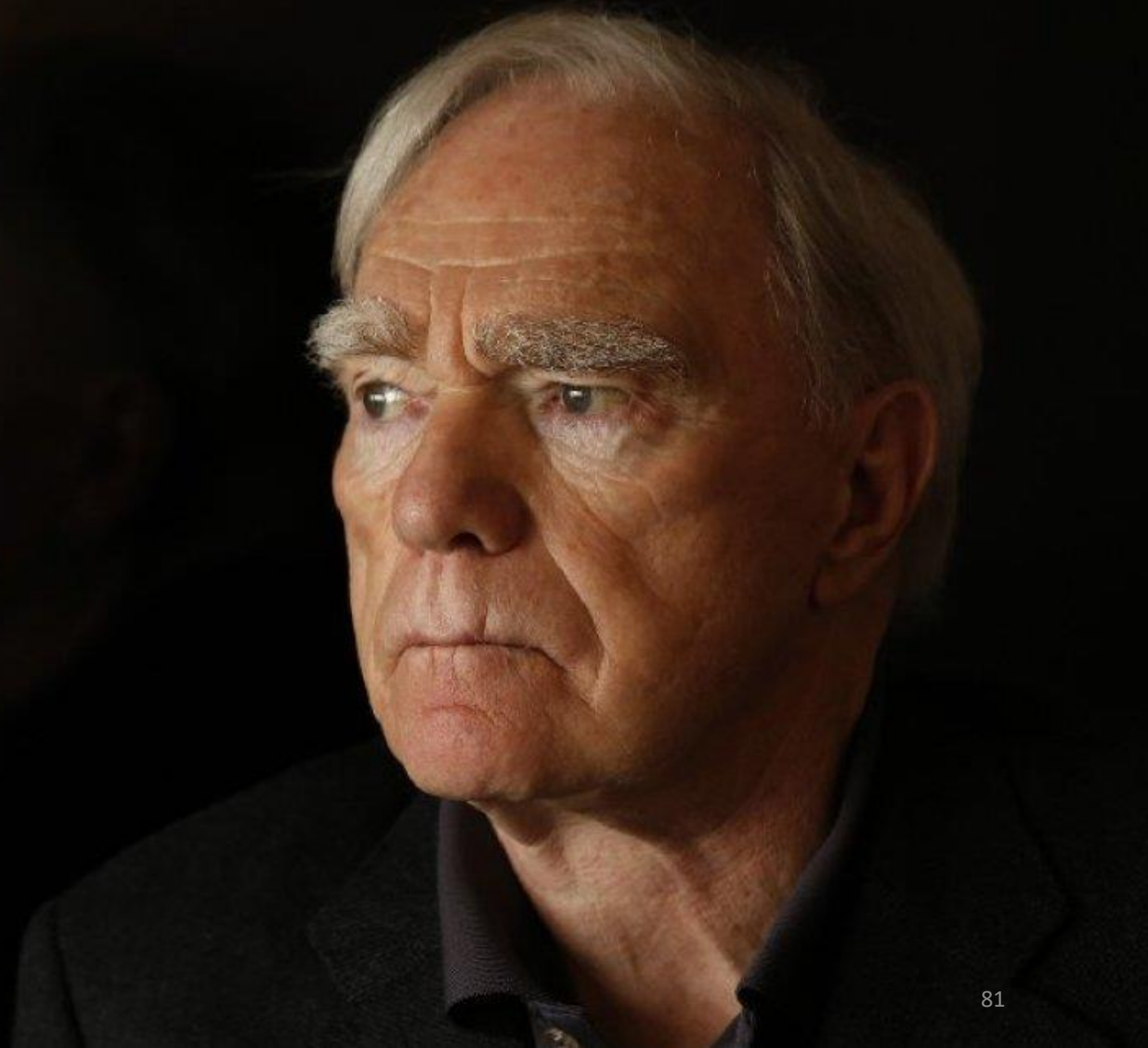
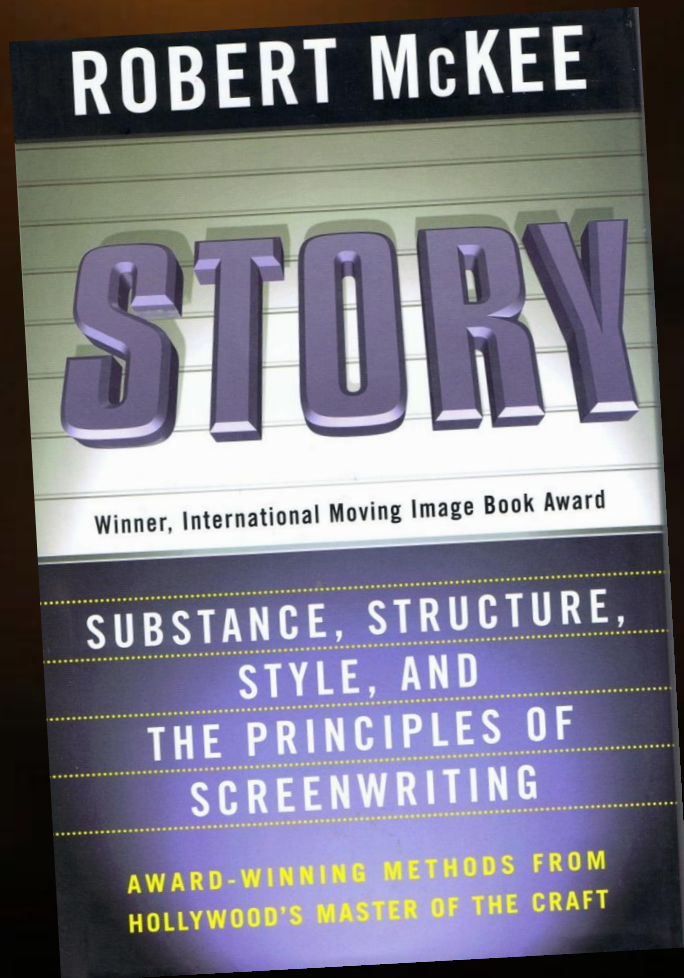
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# The Controlling Idea

The Controlling Idea is **the message you'd like your story to convey** – what you'd like readers/listeners/viewers to remember.

Essentially, it is **the idea at the heart of the story**, shaping and dictating the writer's strategic choices.

**It must be expressible in a single sentence.**



# The difference between Purpose and Controlling Idea

- Purpose = what you want to achieve by telling the story
- Controlling Idea = what message you'd like to communicate in order to achieve your purpose

The Controlling Idea =  
Value + Message

**Value** = the universal human value  
that the story revolves around,  
that comes into the life of the hero

Examples: life/death, love/hate,  
freedom/servitude, truth/lie,  
courage/cowardice, loyalty/betrayal,  
wisdom/ignorance, hope/despair  
strength/weakness, etc.

# Ask yourself: What VALUE is the story about?

- Ideally, the value should be a **universal** one – a feeling, emotion or truth that resonates with us all
- But note: **“Love” isn’t a controlling idea; the specific point you’re making about love is the controlling idea**

What value are these films  
and TV shows about?





















































**Message** = the point we're making  
about the Value

Examples: Love conquers all, Crime pays, Hate destroys,  
Tyranny prevails, etc.

# The battle for The Controlling Idea

- The story progresses by dynamically moving between the positive and negative aspects of the value at stake
- Scene by scene, the positive Idea and negative Counter-Idea “argue” back and forth, creating a dramatized debate
- At the story’s resolution, one of the two voices wins and is revealed to be the story’s Controlling Idea



# What is the Controlling Idea in these films and TV shows?

Value + Message



A family is the strongest force in the world  
when it stays together



A close-up, high-contrast photograph of Marlon Brando as Don Corleone from the movie The Godfather. He is wearing a dark tuxedo with a white shirt and a dark bow tie. His expression is serious and intense, looking slightly off-camera. His right hand is raised, with his index finger pointing upwards. In the background, another man's face is partially visible, looking down. The background is dark with a pattern of bright, circular lights, possibly from a window or a decorative screen.

Never go against the family

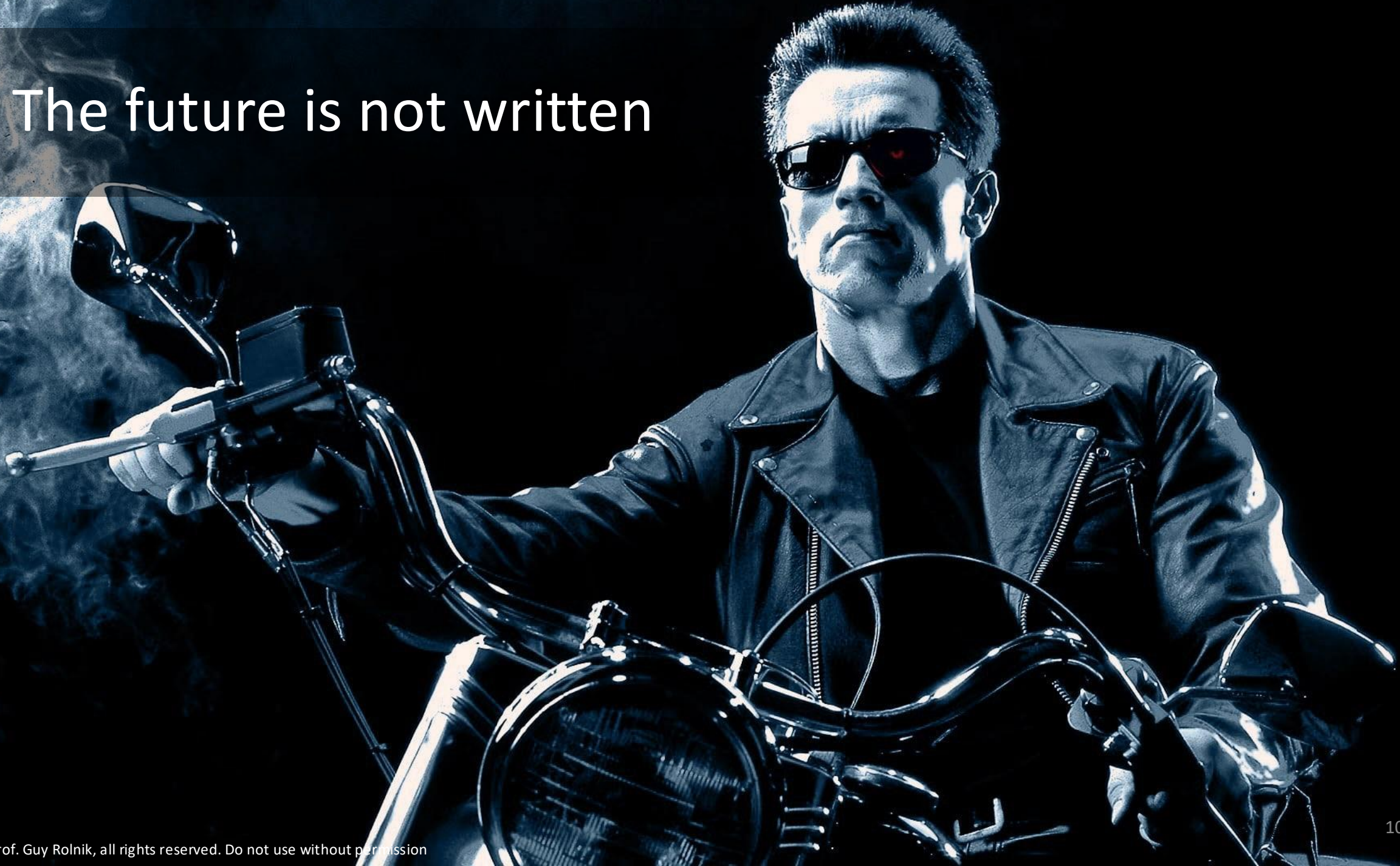


# Hope is a good thing





The future is not written





Friendship can overcome  
the most menacing horrors







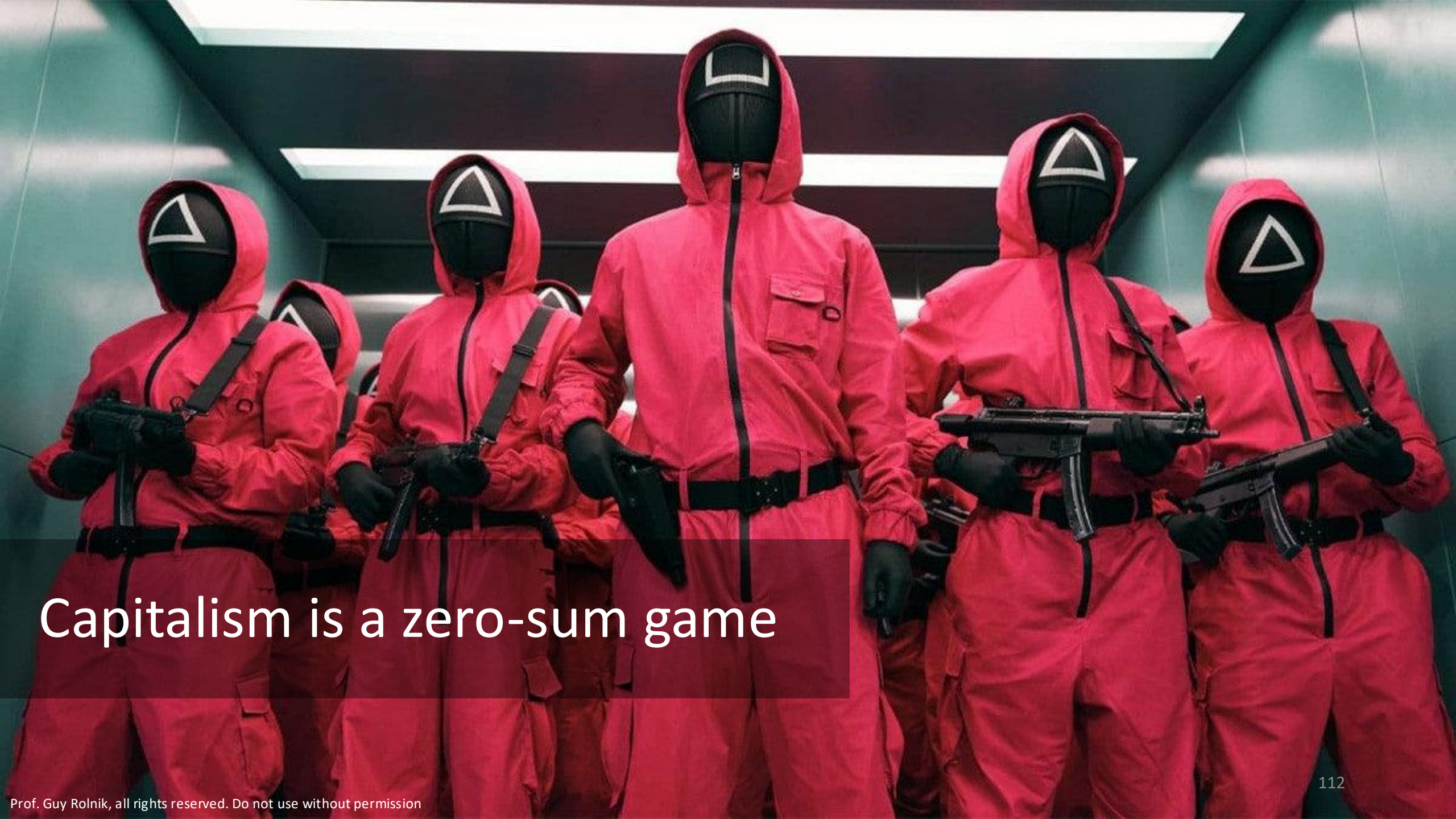
Wealth distorts pretty much everything





With great power comes great responsibility





Capitalism is a zero-sum game



He who holds power, controls the narrative







Extreme commitment  
can lead to self-destruction





Love is worth fighting for



How we feel is not who we are







Charismatic leadership is extremely dangerous

# Controlling ideas from the business world

- Resilience

# Controlling ideas from the business world

- Resilience enables you to overcome any crisis



# Controlling ideas from the business world

- Resilience enables you to overcome any crisis
- Winning

# Controlling ideas from the business world

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- Being a team player

# Controlling ideas from the business world

- Winning is extremely powerful because it's infectious
- Admitting your mistakes is desirable because it's the most effective way to learn and develop
- Being a team player is the key to earning your colleagues' trust



Based on your professional experience, can you think of other business world examples of Controlling Ideas?

Let's practice:  
Controlling Ideas in 60 seconds

# What is the Controlling Idea in these ads?

Value + Message





# Questions

- Who was the audience?
  - What did the teller want the audience to think/feel/do?
- What was the controlling idea?
  - What were the value and the message?
- How clear was it?
  - Why yes? Or why no?

Another one from P&G...



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Let's summarize

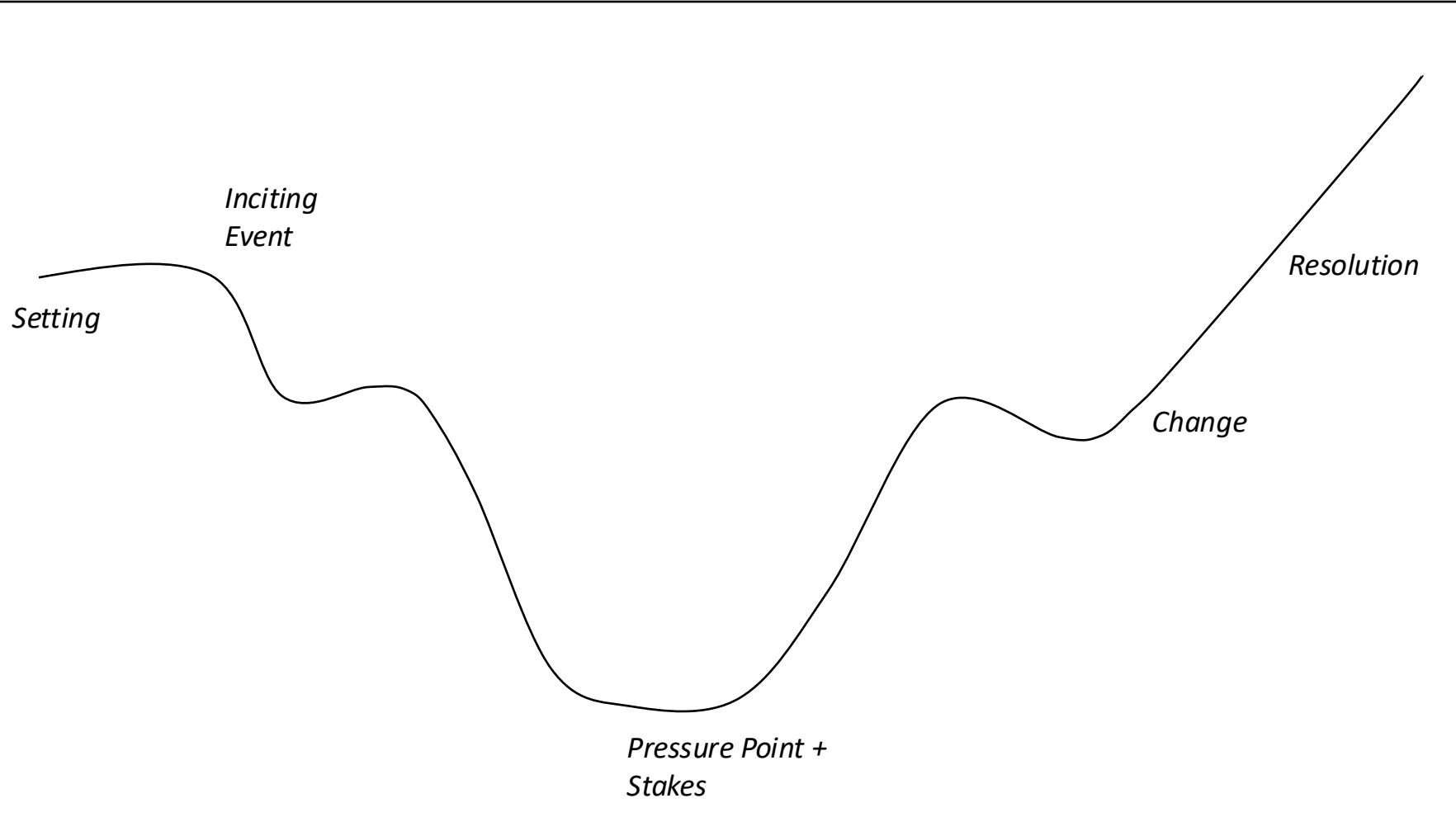
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# Session summary

- Our brains are wired for story
  - Transportation
  - Stories are simulators for life – and a Trojan horse
- Purpose
  - What you want the audience to Think, feel, do
- Audience
  - WIIFT
  - Beliefs
- Controlling Idea
  - The primary message
  - Value + Message

# TAKE IT WITH YOU

## Purpose

- What are you “selling”? (An idea? A product? Yourself?)
- What do you want your audience to Feel? Think? Do?

## Audience

- To whom are you telling your story?
- What are their beliefs in regards to your controlling idea?
- What’s in it for them (why should they care)?

## Controlling Idea

- What message are you communicating in order to achieve your purpose? Value + Message
- What is the universal value? What are you saying about that value?

### Tips:

- Use universal values: life/death, love/hate, freedom/slavery, truth/lie, courage/cowardice, loyalty/betrayal, wisdom/stupidity, strength/weakness, hope/despair...
- Use a common template: X happens because the hero does Y; If you want to do X, you have to do Y; With X comes Y; There’s no X without Y, etc.

Tune in tomorrow,  
when we will enter into conflict...